

original name during the tournament, unlike the Gillette Stadium or Levi's Stadium, is an imposing bowl that holds more than 80,000 people. Thankfully, the seats have been full despite the worst efforts of the transport networks and FIFA, which has priced the tickets far too high.

Atlanta, meanwhile, has been a pleasant surprise. The stadium sits within walking distance of downtown. Having hosted the Olympics before, the city appears comfortable with events of this scale.

The World of Coca-Cola and the Georgia Aquarium provide worthwhile diversions for fans making what is, for many, a once-in-a-lifetime journey.

Here, the media, too, are rather spoiled. The generous buffet lunch is standard fare for cricket reporters back home, but almost mythical for football correspondents. By the second helping, most of us considered extending our stay in Atlanta for "professional reasons".

American cities, however, have

one habit that has repeatedly caught travelling fans and journalists off guard. They go to bed astonishingly early, except for New York. Most downtowns are deserted by 7.30 p.m., and it is almost impossible to find a place either to celebrate or mourn.

After a 7 p.m. match in Philadelphia, we were left wandering through the city in search of dinner. Eventually, we found a taco shop that had heroically ignored whatever curfew everyone else seemed to have observed.

The bus back to New York arrived well past midnight, leaving hundreds of us waiting at an uninspiring bus terminal after Brazil's match against Haiti.

Dallas has perhaps done the best job among the host cities. With nine World Cup matches, the city's organising committee has made a genuine effort to welcome both supporters and the weary press corps. Its media centre is first class, sparing reporters the daily commute to Arlington on non-match days and

providing us with every possible creature comfort.

Argentine fans had turned Klyde Warren Park into a temporary corner of Buenos Aires through their now-famous *banderazo* gatherings.

Locals, initially curious, have happily embraced the colourful parade of cultures that has arrived with the World Cup.

The Japanese remain everyone's favourites, winning admirers not just with their football but with their now-familiar ritual of cleaning the stadium irrespective of the result.

The taxi drivers, however, remain thoroughly puzzled by the excitement among many visiting fans about making pilgrimages to Target and Walmart.

---

**Battle ground:** A general view of the MetLife Stadium during the World Cup Group C match between Brazil and Morocco in East Rutherford, N.J., near New York. AP

